to do so. The investigation report was submitted on July 16. "Based on its recommendations, action was taken," says the CMO, but this has irked Prasada as Pandey was apparently a close aide.

In the case of the Jal Shakti ministry, Khatik bypassed Yogi and sent his resignation letter to Union home minister and BJP No. 2 Amit Shah. In the letter, he made some damning claims, including not being assigned any work in the first 100 days of the government and discrimination because he was a Dalit. "I have no authority...I am not called for meetings. This is an insult to the Dalit community," stated the letter. Things seem sorted after a meeting with Yogi and Swatantra Dev Singh, the cabinet minister for Jal Shakti, on July 22.

Meanwhile, sources say excise minister Nitin Agarwal and additional chief secretary, excise, Sanjay Bhoosreddy are also on a collision course, as are secondary education minister Gulabo Devi and ACS Aradhna Shukla. Bhoosreddy is said to have complete control over the excise department and has reportedly red-flagged and even overturned some of Agarwal's orders. On condition of anonymity, a cabinet minister told INDIA TODAY, "For any important decision, officials talk directly to the CM's office, they don't even keep us in the loop. So what is the point of having a ministry? The public asks us for help but we are unable to do their work because the officials do not listen to us."

CM Adityanath has now asked all the ministers to work in coordination with the officials and "keep an eye on them". The official reason is the "zero tolerance for corruption", but it's evident that there is some unease in the CMO over ministers going public with their grievances. Party functionaries are also unhappy, saying if the situation worsens, it could dent the BJP's image leading into the 2024 Lok Sabha election.

The opposition is already going to town over the recent events. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav says the government's 'zero tolerance' policy against corruption has been exposed. In a statement, he said, "Where there is no respect for being a minister and disrespect for being a Dalit, the logical thing for them [the ministers] to do would be to resign.... At times the bulldozer does go in reverse." ■

MADHYA PRADESH

CHEETAH COALITION TAKES OATH

By Rahul Noronha

Can the world's fastest land animal feel free to run like the wind in an open-air experiment—in a carefully prepared new home? It's the question that nags the minds of all stakeholders. Come August, as India celebrates her 75th Independence Day, a 'coalition' of cheetahs presently in captivity in Namibia are expected to be granted their freedom—more than 8,000 km away from their present habitat.

On July 20, Bhupender Yadav, the Union minister for environment, forests and climate change, and Namibian foreign minister Netumbo Nandi-Ndaitwah inked the much-awaited MoU for the transcontinental transfer of cheetahs to India. The MoU covers other spheres of cooperation between the two countries too, but at this point the focus is on the core part of it: the 'Action Plan for the Introduction of Cheetah in India'. The Cheetah Conservation Fund (CCF) in Namibia has identified and kept ready eight animals, including four males and an equal number of females, to be transferred to India. Top government sources say that an MoU is also expected to be signed with South Africa in the near future. Under that, 12 more cheetahs are expected to sprint all the way to India.

Though the finer details are being worked out, the cheetahs would be brought to the 748 sq km Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh. The animals would be released in eight sub-sections created within a five sq km enclosure at Kuno. Males would be segregated from females; animals that are the prey base of the cheetah have been introduced, and will be increased in the future. The coalition—a group of male cheetahs that stick together and defend their territory—that is expected to be formed while in the enclosure would be released first in the wild. All animals would be radio-collared to be monitored constantly. A team of Namibian wildlife experts will accompany the cheetahs.

The cheetah is synonymous with lightning speed, but, ironically, the cheetah introduction project moved with extreme tardiness. The first attempts to reintroduce cheetahs in India, after they were hunted to extinction in the late 1940s, was made in the '70s, when talks were opened with Iran—the only other Asian country to have wild cheetahs. The plan did not materialise. Decades later, in 2010, the idea was put back on the agenda by then environment minister Jairam Ramesh but had to be shelved after the Supreme Court

WILDLIFE EXPERTS OPPOSED TO THE CHEETAH PROJECT SAY BOTH HABITAT AND PREY BASE AT KUNO ARE INADEQUATE